about 5,700 words

The Helmet

by Douglxss Burley Johnson

Mattie Szabo had her father's binoculars mashed against her face so hard the rubber cups were going to leave red rings around her eyes for an hour. She'd been lying on her stomach on the warm rock of the South Lookout long enough for the stone to press its grit into both elbows, and the hawks still wouldn't come over the knob.

They came down the ridge out of the northeast the way they had all afternoon, mostly red-tails and a few sharp-shins working hard between glides. They rode the northwest wind where it hit the Blue Mountain and climbed the face. Then about a quarter mile out, every bird slid off south over the Lehigh Valley in a long lazy curve around Bake Oven Knob, and picked the ridge back up past the parking lot on the far side, the way creek water goes around a rock.

Mr. Oplinger was sitting behind her on a square of orange foam on the highest boulder, with a clipboard on one knee and a steel clicker in his fist. He was the hawk counter, with a gray mustache and a Phillies cap the sun had faded pink. In the forty minutes since the Szabo kids had walked up the trail, he hadn't clicked that clicker once.

"Fifty years," he said, talking to the valley more than to them. "The birds don't go around the knob. The knob is the whole reason they come this way."

Arpi was sitting three rocks out past Mattie, which was right where Mom had told him not to sit. He was nine, and he had a Butterscotch Krimpet in each hand, eating them in turns with a bite off the left and a bite off the right so neither cake got ahead. His sneakers hung out over a drop that went straight down past the rock face and the tops of the oaks. A puff of wind came up the cliff and blew the hair off his forehead, and he leaned out to watch a crumb fall.

Mattie put the binoculars down and got up on her knees.

"Arpi. Three rocks back."

"I'm watching where it lands."

"It lands at the bottom. Three rocks back, or I tell Mom you ate both Krimpets before the sandwiches."

He scooted back on his butt, one rock and then two, holding the cakes up over his head like they were the ones in danger. Mattie watched every inch with her stomach pulled tight under her ribs, because she knew how Arpi worked, and Arpi walked toward whatever was shiny. Last summer at Dorney Park he'd stepped out of the line for the Thunderhawk to watch a man in a cherry picker paint a sign. Mattie had looked for him for twenty-two minutes while a lady on the loudspeakers read out a little boy in a green Eagles shirt over and over, and Mom ran the midway with her purse banging her hip. They found him sitting on a bench with a funnel cake a stranger had bought him, and he couldn't understand why Mom was crying. Since then Mattie kept him on a string in her head, and that string pulled tight across her chest whenever he got more than a few feet off.

Mom had driven them up Bake Oven Road at two o'clock in the minivan with the Christian station on low. Dad was working another Saturday double at the warehouse in Fogelsville, because since July they'd been cutting hours on the regular shift and only giving them back on weekends. That was the summer Mom taped an index card over the kitchen sink in her square printing and started reading it while she did the dishes. It was also the summer Mattie watched her sit in the Giant parking lot after a grocery run with the engine off, the receipt in her lap, and her forehead on the steering wheel, dry-eyed and not moving while the ice cream got soft in the back. Mattie kept her eyes on the cart corral and her mouth shut the whole time. When Mom finally raised her head and turned the key, Mattie reached over and turned the radio up for her.

At the lot Mom handed Mattie the backpack with the sandwiches and told her to keep their phones on, stay with her brother, and be back right here at five-thirty. Then she sat a minute with her hands on the wheel, looking up at the oaks turning gold over the yellow game lands gate.

"Pap Heller used to bring me up here when I was Arpi's age," she said. "He'd sit me on the rocks with a thermos of cocoa and go fuss over that old shelter like it was his own house." She laughed at herself and told them to go on.

They'd climbed onto the rocks at about a quarter after two, and Mattie had tried to text Mom a picture of the hawks swinging wide, but the picture sat there with the little circle spinning around and around until she gave up. She'd had full bars down at the gate.

Lonnie Rehrig walked up the trail about forty minutes later. He came up over the last boulder red in the face and wet at the hairline, wearing his father's Army field jacket in sun warm enough that Arpi had his sleeves pushed up. The jacket hung to his knees, and he didn't say hi.

He sat down on the rock next to Mattie's, dug a roofing nail out of the pocket, and started scratching at an old spray-painted heart on the stone, making a thin grinding squeak she could feel in her back teeth.

The Rehrigs lived next door, and Mattie knew every sound that house used to make when Lonnie's dad was home. She knew the storm door banging back against the siding hard enough to rattle the Szabos' kitchen window, the Ford idling in the driveway with the hole in its muffler, and a voice coming through two walls on Friday nights with words too thick to make out. Then, around eleven, Lonnie would be sitting on the Szabos' back step with his hood up, and Mom would walk out with a plate of whatever was left without asking him a single question. In July the Ford backed out and went to Hazleton and didn't come back, and since then the Rehrig house hadn't made a sound. Lonnie's mom worked nights at the hospital now, so when Mattie got up to pee at two in the morning, she could see the blue of Lonnie's screen still on in his window. There was an oil stain in the driveway in the shape of the truck, and Lonnie had worn the jacket every day since.

"You rode all the way up?" Mattie said.

"Saw your mom's van go." He kept scratching. "You weren't answering."

"There's no bars up here."

"Nobody gets bars past the gate. It's like the whole mountain turned its phone off." He blew the grit out of the scratch. The knuckles on that hand were scabbed across all four with fresh scabs, and when he saw her looking he put the hand back in the jacket pocket.

"Let's hit the shelter," Lonnie said, kicking a pebble off the edge. "High school kids leave stuff."

"We have to be at the lot by five-thirty."

"It's like a half mile, Szabo."

So they went, crossing the top of the knob past the old concrete pad behind the lookout, which was a square of cracked foundation with four rusted bolt stubs sticking up at the corners where a light tower had stood when mail planes flew the valley at night. Arpi stomped right across the middle of it in his orange vest, and Mattie barely looked. Past it the trail dropped off the north side of the ridge over the rock slide, where the boulders were as big as cars and the white blazes were painted right on the stone.

Arpi went first, because Arpi always went first. He hopped from a flat rock onto a tilted one, and when the tilted stone rocked under him, his left leg slid straight down into the gap between two boulders all the way to the hip. No yell came out of him. He just stopped, folded over with one leg gone into the mountain and both hands still up, while the last Krimpet went tumbling down the crack out of sight.

Mattie got there without remembering the rocks in between. She hooked both arms under his armpits and pulled him up, and he came out of the crack slow and scraping, his jeans pushed up to the knee and a long raw scrape down his shin where beads of blood came up like a row of red buttons. She sat him on the flat rock and held onto the back of his vest with her fist.

"My Krimpet," Arpi said.

"Forget the Krimpet."

"It's down there. It's down there forever."

Her hands wouldn't stop shaking, so she kept one of them knotted in his vest and made him walk in front of her the rest of the way down. When she looked back up the slide, Lonnie was standing on a boulder above them with his hands in the jacket pockets, looking off north at the next ridge over. He hadn't come down to help, and he hadn't even watched.

Past the North Lookout boulders they took the blue blazes down to the shelter, which sat low in the trees as a lean-to of old chestnut logs turned silver with age, with a plank floor raised off the ground for sleeping. There were beer cans in the leaves around back, and the air under the trees smelled like wet bark and mouse. There was less sound down here than there ought to be with three kids crashing around, the way a classroom drops to a hush when the principal walks in.

Lonnie checked along the back wall and came up with an empty mango vape, clicked it twice, and stuck it behind his ear like a pencil. Arpi pulled the empty Krimpet wrapper out of his vest pocket to look at it one more time, and the wind took it out of his fingers and slid it under the plank floor. Because Arpi never let a wrapper go anywhere Mom might find out about, he went in after it on his belly.

He came out backward with leaves in his hair, dragging an old Army helmet by its strap.

It was the round steel style from the war movies, with the olive paint faded to the brown of a dry creek bed, a dent above the left side, and a canvas chin strap with a brass buckle turned green. Mattie peeled the leather liner back with one finger. Two small letters, H.H., were scratched into the steel underneath with a nail point, and the whole thing smelled of mildew and pine.

Arpi put it on before anyone could stop him, and it came down over his eyebrows and ears and sat on the bridge of his nose.

"It's quiet in here," he said from under it. "It's like when you put your head under the bathwater."

"Private Szabo," Lonnie said. "Ten-hut."

Arpi saluted with the wrong hand and marched in a circle on the plank floor, and Mattie laughed and saluted back, so for a minute it was a good Saturday again. Then Lonnie took the helmet off Arpi's head, set it crooked on his own, and rapped the top with his knuckles. It made a dull clank like a pot lid.

"And take the helmet of salvation!" he said in a deep TV preacher voice. "Ephesians six seventeen! My mom made me do Bible school at your church, Szabo. I got a flannel-board certificate."

Mattie laughed again, and Lonnie kept going, dropping his voice until it roughened and pulling his shoulders up until it was his dad.

"Lonnie. Lonnie! Get out here. You think I don't see that bike laying in the yard?"

It was the Friday voice down to the word, the one that came through two walls. Arpi stopped marching, and Mattie's laugh stopped in her throat. Lonnie stood there with the helmet down on his eyebrows, doing the voice a second longer than a joke goes, and the hand he'd raised to point at nobody was shaking.

Then he knocked on the steel again. "It's just a pot, see?" he said in his own voice. "No angels. No Holy Ghost." He pulled it off and tossed it to her, and she caught it against her chest, heavy as a cast-iron pan and cold from lying under the boards.

Mattie didn't put it on, because she didn't want to wear it for a joke after Lonnie had worn it for one. She slid the chin strap over her wrist and let the helmet hang there, knocking against her leg as they climbed back up toward the knob without anyone saying a word.

The light had changed while they were under the trees. It came through the oaks low and slanting and orange now, and their shadows stretched out long across the rocks. Up on the knob Mr. Oplinger was standing, rolling up his square of foam and snapping the clip on his board shut.

His eyes went past them to the old tower pad, and he rubbed his jaw.

"My dad used to say there were giants in the earth in those days," he said, "and whatever they left behind still likes a high place." Then he laughed through his nose like it was an old joke he was tired of.

Mr. Oplinger told them it was game lands and bow season, keep that orange vest on the little one, and be off these rocks before dark. He asked if their mom was coming, and Mattie said five-thirty, and he said good. Then he walked down the trail toward the lot with his thermos knocking on his hip, and Mattie watched the pink cap get small between the trunks until the trees closed behind it. After that it was just the three of them on the mountain.

"Mattie," Arpi said. "How come the leaves are like that?"

Oak leaves lay heaped against the boulders and rattled every time the wind came over, but on the concrete pad they lay in a ring. Every leaf lay flat with its stem pointing out toward the trees like the spokes on her bike, and not one of them moved. The wind pushed Mattie's bangs into her eyes and sent a whole drift skittering off the rocks behind her, while the leaves on the pad didn't budge.

Arpi started toward it, and Mattie caught him by the hood of his sweatshirt.

"Don't step on that."

"Why?"

She opened her mouth, shut it again, and kept her fist in his hood.

Under the wind there was a hum. She'd taken it for the big lines down along 309, except 309 was miles off, and this came up through the rock into the soles of her sneakers and the fillings in her back teeth, low and steady like a refrigerator in an empty house.

She pulled her phone out to check the time, because the sun was sitting right down on top of Bear Rocks to the west and Mom would be pulling into the lot. The screen said No Service, and the clock said 2:14, which was the minute they'd climbed onto the rocks. She turned it off and on, and it came back up and said 2:14 again while the sun kept sinking behind the ridge.

"We have to go," she said. "Lonnie. We have to go now."

Lonnie didn't answer. He'd walked out past the South Lookout to the farthest ledge, which was the narrow one where only the high school kids went to show off, and sat down on it with his legs hanging over the drop.

Then the red-tail came.

It came down the ridge late and low and all by itself, a big bird with the last sun lighting up the rust in its tail. This one didn't slide off south like the others. It came straight at the knob on stiff wings, and Mattie had time to think, there, finally, before it reached the air over the concrete pad and stopped cold, the way a bird stops when it flies into a picture window. Every feather on it flared out at once, and it screamed. It was a long ragged scream, and up close it went straight into her stomach. The hawk beat backward, fell off the wind, caught itself a few feet above the treetops, and flew back up the ridge the way it had come, flapping hard and low like a dog was after it. Three of its breast feathers drifted down slow, turning over and over until they landed on the pad and lay flat in the ring with their quills pointed out, the same as the leaves.

Arpi's mouth was open.

"It hit the air," he said. "Mattie, it hit the air."

She didn't answer him. She had both hands on him now, one on his hood and one on his vest, and through the back of his ribs she could feel his heart going fast like a rabbit's. Nobody

had touched them or come near them, and it was just the three of them and the hum and the leaves, the sun going down, and her phone saying 2:14.

Arpi turned his head toward the valley.

"Mattie," he said in a calm and interested voice. "Who's saying my name?"

"Nobody's saying your name."

"The man. Over there." He pointed with his whole arm, past the pad and the lookout, at the empty air over the drop. "He keeps saying Arpád."

Nobody called him Arpád except Grandma Szabo on the phone at Christmas. Mattie looked where he was pointing and saw only air turning blue over the valley and the first lights coming on down in Germansville. Arpi's face was the face he'd had looking up at the man in the cherry picker, calm and curious and already leaning. The string in her chest pulled so tight she could hardly breathe around it, and she pulled him back against her legs and held on.

Down below, a truck downshifted on Bake Oven Road, and the sound came all the way up the mountain from a big engine coughing through a muffler with a hole in it.

"That's him," Lonnie said from the ledge.

"Lonnie, that's anybody's truck."

"It's the Ford. I know the hole in it." He said it low, almost gentle, with his face turned down toward the road. Then he looked back at her over his shoulder, and his voice went sharp as a slapped hand. "Don't you tell me what I know, Szabo. You don't know one thing about my dad. Your dad comes home."

She took that and didn't give it back. The sun dropped behind Bear Rocks, so all at once the light on the knob was thin and blue while the cold came up off the stone, and Lonnie dug his

father's angle-head flashlight out of the jacket and smacked it against his palm until it came on yellow.

The leaves on the pad had started to glow from underneath, with a pale white line running around the ring of them like light coming under a door.

Then the light came up off the pad and turned.

It swung around slow in a beam as wide as a barn door, turning white and then green and then white again, sweeping the oaks the way the old tower light must have swept the dark for the mail planes, with no tower under it, only air. A shape stood on the pad inside the beam, and Mattie made herself look right at it. It stood taller than the oaks, and it was thin the way a tower frame is thin, all long legs and narrow shoulders, and where its face should have been the light came out.

The beam passed over Arpi. He twisted down and out of his orange vest like a cat out of a collar, left it hanging empty in her fist, and walked toward the lip of the South Lookout, grinning at the light.

The beam passed over Mattie, and she heard her own voice inside her head, the one she used on herself in the bathroom mirror. It said Mom sat in the Giant lot with her forehead on the wheel because of her. It said Arpi was going off that rock and it would be her fault, the way it was always her fault, and nobody could hear her up here, and nobody ever could. Her legs felt heavy as wet sand, and for a second she stood there and let it talk.

Then she dropped the vest and ran, staying bent over under the beam until she caught Arpi by the back of his sweatshirt one step from the lip, and they went down hard on the stone together. Her elbow skidded and burned and came away wet, and past Arpi's head there was only air and the tops of the trees a long way down.

Arpi kicked. "Let go. The man says you can see our house from the end."

Mattie got her knee on his back, jammed the helmet down on his head, and fed the green brass prong through the first hole it would reach.

"God," she said. "Please. Keep his head."

The beam swung around and hit the steel, making a sound like sleet on the roof of a car. Arpi stopped kicking and blinked up at her from under the rim, and his face was his own face.

"Why's it so loud in here?" he said. "He's still talking, but it's outside now." He wiped his nose on his sleeve. "It isn't true, what he says. Mom says I'm her best surprise."

She pulled him to the scrub oak that grew out of a crack behind the lookout and wrapped his arms around the trunk. "Hold that tree. Do not let go of it."

Out on the end of the far ledge Lonnie was standing now, toes over the edge, hands loose, his flashlight still on behind him. The beam had stopped turning and sat on him, holding white.

"Dad?" Lonnie said.

Mattie heard it then out loud in the wind, a man's voice that sounded rough and friendly, with cigarettes and truck stop coffee in it. "Come on out, bud. Truck's parked right down there. I came back for the jacket."

Arpi already had his fingers on the buckle.

"No," Mattie said. "Keep it."

"Lonnie needs it." He held the helmet out with both hands, and she watched his chin start to shake and his eyes fill up, and he held it out anyway. "Take it. I'll hold the tree. I'll say my verse."

She took it and went out onto the ledge on her hands and knees. The wind had swung around to come off the dark north side of the ridge, pushing at her back like a hand, steady and

hard toward the drop. Behind her Arpi hugged the oak and said his memory verse from Mrs. Kistler's class with all the old words, his voice cracking. "I will lift up mine eyes unto the hills, from whence cometh my help."

The voice in her head said she was going to slip, and since he wanted to go she should let him go, because God was a flannel board in a church basement with the corners peeling off.

Mattie stopped crawling and put her forehead down on the cold rock.

"I can't do this part," she said into the stone. "You do it, God. I'll hold on."

The words were hardly out of her mouth before the wind quit. For three heartbeats there was no wind at all, only the hum, and Lonnie leaned out a little over the dark. Then the wind came back from the other way, up the face of the cliff out of the valley, hard and warm as an August night, smelling of cut corn and chimney smoke. It hit Mattie full in the face, pushed her back from the edge, and rocked Lonnie on his heels. Down in the trees below the cliff she heard wings starting to beat, a lot of them like pigeons going up off a barn roof all at once, and the sound was coming up.

She got her knees under her and crawled on into that warm wind until she could touch his sneaker.

Lonnie turned around with the beam on his back and his face dark against it, and when he opened his mouth his father's voice came out of him in that mean Friday night tone. "Go home, Szabo. Nobody asked you up here. Your old man works doubles so he don't have to look at you." He kicked at her, and when she caught his ankle he came down on one knee and swung wild, and the back of his hand caught her across the mouth so her lip split against her teeth and her whole cheek rang.

Through the ringing she saw the pad, where the tall thing stood in its light behind Lonnie. When Lonnie drew his arm back to swing again, its long arm drew back at the same time, slow like a man working a puppet on a stick, and when Lonnie's mouth opened, the light where its face should be opened with it. Mattie watched that happen twice, and then she knew who she was fighting. It was the thing on the pad, and the boy in front of her was Lonnie, who sat on their back step at eleven at night with his hood up and ate Mom's leftovers off a paper plate. She didn't hit him back. She took the second swing on her shoulder, grabbed his father's jacket in both fists and held on, and turned her face past him up into the light at the thing standing in it.

"You can't have him," she said to it.

Then she jammed the helmet down on Lonnie's head with him bucking under her. He clawed at the rim, and she put her whole weight on it, got the canvas strap under his chin, and pushed the brass prong at the hole. It was stiff with eighty years of rust, and her fingers were slick with blood off her elbow, so it slipped. "Greater is He that is in me than he that is in the world," Mattie said right up into that light, steady, the way Mom read it off the card over the sink with her hands in the dishwater, with her knees planted on the rock and her thumb already pushing the prong again. It went through, and she cinched the strap tight against his jaw.

The beam came down on Lonnie square, and the helmet rang like sleet on a car. Lonnie stopped fighting on his knees, and Mattie watched his face come back to him as he saw what was standing on the pad.

"That's not my dad," he said. "It doesn't have a face."

Up the warm wind came the hawks, dozens and then hundreds rising up the cliff in the dusk when every hawk on the mountain ought to have been asleep. They went past the ledge so close she heard the air rip through their feathers and turned in a slow column over the knob. In

the gaps between them Mattie saw other shapes standing on the wind, bigger than any bird, with wings that went up past where her eyes could follow, set in a ring around the knob. When she looked straight at one it blurred like a word stared at too long, and she didn't try twice.

The thing swung its light onto the scrub oak, and Arpi's arms came loose from the trunk as he took one step toward the drop with his face slack again. Between one blink and the next, one of the tall ones was beside him, and a hand as wide as a snow shovel came down flat on his back and set him against the tree, gentle and sure, the way Mom would catch a glass going off the counter and set it back without looking. Arpi grabbed the trunk and hung on.

Its beam came back around at the ledge, and another of the tall ones stepped down out of the hawks and stood between the pad and the two of them with its wings half open, like someone holding a storm door wide in a hard wind so it wouldn't bang. The beam broke on it like creek water on a boulder and went around. In the shadow it made, Lonnie grabbed Mattie's wrist hard enough to hurt, and they crawled backward on their bellies an inch and then a foot at a time with the helmet scraping stone, until their sneakers hit the scrub oak where Arpi was saying "whence" over and over because he'd forgotten the rest.

Then the ring of wings closed on the pad. Big blurred shapes came down through the hawks while the hum climbed to a whine like a dentist's drill, and the tall thing folded in on its own light the way an umbrella folds and went down into the concrete like water down a drain. The white line around the ring of leaves went out like a pilot light. When the hum quit, Mattie's phone buzzed against her leg, three times, four, five.

It was dark on the knob, with stars coming out over the Carbon County side and Germansville strung out yellow below. The wind blew ordinary and cool from the northwest. Lonnie's flashlight lay where he'd dropped it, and in its yellow circle the pad was only cracked

concrete with four rusty bolts and the leaves lying on it any which way, rattling when the wind went over. Mattie pulled her phone out with shaking fingers and saw the clock said 6:41, the bars were back, and there were eleven missed calls from Mom.

Lonnie sat with his back against the oak, fumbled the strap loose, and held the helmet in his lap.

"I heard it ring," he said.

"I know."

"In the shelter it was just a pot." He turned it over in his hands. "It didn't do anything for me in the shelter."

"You weren't asking Him for anything in the shelter," Mattie said.

Lonnie didn't say anything for a few minutes. Arpi came and sat against his other side without asking, and Lonnie let him. The vape had fallen from behind his ear somewhere out on the ledge. Then he reached over and touched the corner of Mattie's mouth, where her lip had puffed up fat and split, and pulled his hand back fast.

"I hit you out there," he said. "I said that stuff about your dad."

"It was working your arm," Mattie said. "I watched it. I wasn't fighting you."

"That thing you said. The greater one. Say it again."

Mattie said it again, slower, leaning on the in me. Lonnie put his hand flat on top of the helmet and talked out loud with his eyes open, looking at the dark where the pad was.

"Jesus? Okay. I don't know how to do this," he said. "That thing got in me and had my dad's voice, and You had the wind. I pick You. You get in me instead. Amen or whatever."

"It's just amen," Arpi said. "You don't need the whatever."

"Amen," Lonnie said. He wiped his face on the jacket sleeve and laughed once, wet. "Amen. Okay."

They were coming out of the trees by flashlight when headlights swung across the lot, and Mom's minivan came back up off Bake Oven Road, where she'd been driving the shoulder with her window down calling their names, and pulled into the lot fast enough to spray gravel. She was out of it before it stopped rocking, phone in her hand, and she didn't yell. She looked at Mattie's mouth, dumped the Turkey Hill soda out of the cup in her holder, wrapped the ice in a napkin, and held it on the lip herself. Then she saw what was hanging off Lonnie's wrist, and she turned on the dome light and took the helmet in both hands. Her thumb went right into the dent above the left side, like it knew where to go.

"That's Pap Heller's," she said, peeling the liner back to show the H.H. "He came home from the war with this dent in it. He kept it under that shelter floor, and he said it was for whoever needed it more than he did."

Mom drove them down the mountain without the radio on.

The next Saturday the wind came out of the northwest again. On the way up, Arpi crawled under the shelter floor on his belly and slid the helmet back where he'd found it, and Lonnie checked twice that it was all the way in. Then they climbed the knob, and Mr. Oplinger couldn't click that clicker fast enough. The hawks came straight down the ridge and straight over the knob, low over the old tower pad, so close Mattie could hear the wind in their feathers. Lonnie sat beside Mr. Oplinger with Mr. Szabo's binoculars, calling them out loud as they came. He'd come to church with the Szabos on Sunday and sat between Arpi and Mom, and he'd sung the hymns wrong and loud. A big red-tail came over the pad and right over their heads, close

enough that its shadow went across Lonnie's hands, and he followed it with the glasses until it was gone, then wiped the rubber cups on his sleeve and handed them back to Mattie.

"Fifty years," Mr. Oplinger said, clicking. "I never saw them come over like this."

Arpi had a Krimpet in each hand again, taking a bite off the left and a bite off the right. "God put the lid back on," he said with his mouth full. "The big brothers just did what He said."

END